MSC MARRIAGE AND FAMILY THERAPY

PROGRAMME DOCUMENT · LECTURE LIBRARY

PD 01

Programme document

Teaching and Assessment Guide for Lecturers

PROGRAMME

For students and lecturers · read before the semester

One of four programme documents that frame the 28-volume lecture library: the student handbook, the lecturer's teaching and assessment guide, the figure index and the visual figure gallery.

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Teaching and Assessment Guide for Lecturers

This volume is one of 28 course books that together cover the whole MSc Marriage and Family Therapy taught programme. Each book is written to carry a 14–16 week semester on its own: every week pairs a core idea with the practice that follows from it, a worked case, and a reflective task, and each book closes with an integration chapter, a glossary and a self-assessment paper with model answers.

The books are designed to be read straight through before the semester begins, revisited week by week, and used again in revision. Cross-references point to the other volumes where a topic is treated in more depth.

How to cite this volume

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A note on the case material

All families, couples and individuals in this book are fictional composites. They are written to teach pattern recognition, not to describe any real person. Nothing here replaces supervised clinical practice, professional registration, legal advice or medical care; legal content is orientation only and must be checked against the law of the relevant jurisdiction.

The lecture library

Twenty-eight self-contained course books carry the taught programme: eight in Semester One, seven in Semester Two, seven in Semester Three including the thesis, and six electives. The volume you are holding is marked in the margin.

Code	Course	Semester	Units
MFT 701	Fundamentals of Marriage and Family Therapy	One	1.71
MFT 702	Theories of Family Therapy	One	1.71
MFT 703	Human Development Across the Lifespan	One	1.71
MFT 704	Ethical and Legal Issues in Therapy	One	1.71
MFT 705	Research Methods in Marriage and Family Therapy	One	1.71
MFT 706	Clinical Practice and Techniques	One	1.71
MFT 707	Assessment and Diagnosis in Family Therapy	One	1.71
MFT 708	Cultural Competence in Therapy	One	1.71
MFT 709	Group Therapy Techniques	Two	1.71
MFT 710	Couples Therapy	Two	1.71
MFT 711	Child and Adolescent Therapy	Two	1.71
MFT 712	Crisis Intervention Strategies	Two	1.71
MFT 713	Substance Abuse and Family Dynamics	Two	1.71
MFT 714	Trauma-Informed Care	Two	1.71
MFT 715	Family Systems Theory	Two	1.71
MFT 716	Communication Skills in Therapy	Three	1.71
MFT 717	Psychopathology in Families	Three	1.71
MFT 718	Intimacy and Relationship Dynamics	Three	1.71
MFT 719	Family Life Cycle and Transitions	Three	1.71
MFT 720	Supervision and Consultation in Therapy	Three	1.71
MFT 721	Research Methodology	Three	1.71
MFT 722	Professional Development and Self-Care	Electives	1.71
MFT 723	Special Populations in Therapy	Electives	1.71
MFT 724	Family Law and Advocacy	Electives	1.71
MFT 725	Integrative Approaches in Therapy	Electives	1.71
MFT 726	Neurobiology of Relationships	Electives	1.71
MFT 727	Play Therapy Techniques	Electives	1.71
MFT 770	Master Thesis	Three	1.71

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> For the person delivering the course. Short, practical, and designed so a new lecturer can pick up a book and teach it next week.

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1. The default session shape (2 hours + 1 hour practical)

Time	Segment	Purpose
0–10 min	**Check-in round**	One sentence each: "one thing that stayed with you from last week". Builds the relational field you will later teach about.
10–25 min	**Retrieval quiz**	Five closed questions on last week's material, answered individually then in pairs. Retrieval, not recognition.
25–60 min	**Lecture block 1**	One big idea, one case, one diagram. Never more than one new diagram per block.
60–70 min	**Break**	Non-negotiable; protects attention for block 2.
70–100 min	**Lecture block 2**	The model applied to the same case; show a recorded or live demonstration.
100–120 min	**Whole-group debrief**	"What would you have done differently?" Collect on the board; do not resolve everything.
Practical hour	**Skills triad**	Observer / therapist / client, 12-minute rounds, structured feedback sheet, rotate.

The observer is not passive. Give the observer a single narrow task per round — count the closed questions, note every time the therapist interrupted, or track who spoke most. Narrow observation is what makes feedback usable.

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2. Assessment design principles

1. **Assess the skill, not the vocabulary.** A student who can define "enactment" and cannot conduct one should not pass the clinical component.
2. **Use unseen cases for exams and seen cases for assignments.** Seen cases teach; unseen cases test.
3. **Mark formulations on reasoning, not on agreement with your formulation.** The question is "is this hypothesis supported by the evidence in the case and testable?", not "is it the one I would have had?"
4. **Require risk documentation in every clinical assignment.** A formulation with no risk screen is incomplete, however elegant.

Sample marking rubric for a case formulation (30%)

Criterion	Weight	What excellence looks like
Systemic description	20%	Circular, multi-person, includes context, no single-villain language

Criterion	Weight	What excellence looks like
Evidence use	20%	Claims traced to specific case detail; gaps named
Formulation quality	25%	5-P grid coherent; one clear focus; explicitly testable
Model application	15%	Technique justified by formulation, not by preference
Ethics, culture and risk	10%	Risk screen, power, culture and consent addressed
Writing and referencing	10%	Plain professional prose; accurate APA-style referencing

3. Teaching the difficult topics

Suicide and self-harm (MFT 712). Do not lecture about risk assessment without demonstrating one. Use a scripted role-play with a colleague, then let students practise in triads with a checklist. Expect anxiety; name it and use it.

Intimate partner violence (MFT 704, 710, 712). Never role-play a live violent couple in a whole-group format without a clear stop signal and a pre-brief. Screen separately, always. Teach the difference between situational couple violence and coercive control early, because the treatment implications diverge sharply.

Culture (MFT 708). Avoid the "cultural knowledge" trap. Teach students to ask, not to assume, and to locate themselves on the same dimensions they are assessing.

Trauma (MFT 714). Students with their own trauma histories will be activated by this material. Announce content in advance, offer an opt-out route that is not stigmatising, and keep a referral pathway for students as well as clients.

4. Running the skills labs

- **Groups of three, fixed for the semester.** Continuity produces trust; changing groups each week produces polite performances.
- **Twelve-minute rounds, three-minute feedback, rotate.** Protect the time strictly; over-running is the most common facilitation error.
- **Feedback sandwich is banned.** Use: "what I saw", "what it did to me as the client", "one thing to keep, one thing to try".
- **Record one round per student per month** (with consent) so they can see themselves rather than argue with feedback.
- **The lecturer circulates and joins rounds as a co-therapist**, which is more powerful modelling than any demonstration.

5. Common student difficulties (and what to do)

Difficulty	What it looks like	Response
Advice-giving	Answers every problem with a solution	Ban "have you tried…" for one full session; require a question instead
Individual focus	Interviews one person while the family watches	Require every 5 minutes to include a different person's voice
Anxiety-driven over-structuring	Fills silence, runs a curriculum	Teach deliberate silence; debrief what the silence produced
Rescuing	Works harder than the family	Assign a session where the student does 30% less talking and reports what happened
Theory-reciting	Names models, cannot enact them	Move assessment from "explain" to "demonstrate"
Boundary blur	Becomes the family's friend	Review the case plan and the fee/contact policy together

6. Materials, ethics and logistics

- **Recorded sessions:** obtain written consent from every adult participant and a guardian for minors, explain who will view the recording, and store it encrypted with a deletion date.
- **Live supervision:** brief the family in advance that a supervisor may call in; agree the signal the therapist can use to pause.
- **Role-play disclosure:** state at the start of the semester that personal material shared in skills practice is confidential within the group but that students may always decline to use their own experience.
- **Assessment security:** rotate unseen cases each year and keep the case bank in one place.

7. A suggested semester rhythm

Week	Focus
1	Orientation, contracting, baseline quiz, first skills triad
2–5	Core content blocks; formative case formulation in Week 4 (ungraded feedback)
6	Mid-semester skills assessment (pass/fail gate, resit available)
7–10	Application weeks; guest clinician or recorded session; assignment set in Week 8
11	Assignment submission; peer review session
12–13	Integration weeks; students present their formulation to the group
14	Revision, seen-case walkthrough, exam briefing
15	Examination

Week	Focus
16	Feedback, marks, progression meeting

8. If you only have three hours with this book

Teach Week 1 (framing), the week containing the central model, and the integration chapter. Set the practicals as self-directed triad work with a submitted log. That preserves the spine of the course: what the work is, how it is done, and how it fits together.

9. Printing and distributing the materials

Every course is available as a finished A4 PDF in `../pdf/`; the whole programme is in `MFT-Library-Complete-28-volumes.pdf`. Practical notes for running a semester from the print edition:

- **Set the reading from the page numbers, not the chapter titles.** Each PDF's contents page carries real page numbers, and the bookmarks in the sidebar match them, so "read pages 6–9 before Thursday" is unambiguous.
- **Print the week, not the book.** The weekly sections are self-contained: the idea, the practice, a case and a reflective task. A 14-week course prints to roughly 25 pages of core text.
- **Photocopy the practicals.** Callout panels (case, practical, caution, debate, reflection) are set in tinted boxes precisely so they can be lifted onto a worksheet without re-typing.
- **Licence.** CC BY 4.0: copy, adapt and translate freely with attribution. If you change a book, mark it as changed and keep the attribution line from the imprint page.
- **Regenerating.** After editing the Markdown, run `python3 scripts/build_pdfs.py --complete` and both the individual volumes and the merged file update, with contents and bookmarks rebuilt automatically.